

Fantasy Football Expert Narratives - Signal or Storytelling?

It's the first week of the NFL season, and your fantasy football team is under pressure. Thousands of users are reading expert start/sit columns, waiver wire writeups, and weekly player outlooks. You've seen dozens of different analysts online, each one claiming that they can help you make the best decisions for your roster. It is time to finally investigate the reliability of these analysts who claim to have knowledge that can benefit your fantasy football team. You are going to dive into the sentiment of fantasy media, asking the question: Can analyst outlook help predict NFL player performance, or is it mostly narrative?

Fantasy football is a game where participants build virtual teams of real NFL players and score points based on those players' weekly in game statistics. This makes forecasting performance central to every lineup decision. To guide those decisions, fans rely heavily on media content where analysts suggest players to start/sit, talk about who is available on the waiver wire, and provide tailored rankings. These articles are written by analysts who use confident or cautious language to frame their expectations. At first glance, positive writeups should mean good fantasy weeks, negative writeups should mean bad ones. But in sports media, confidence and prediction are not always the same thing. Analysts may be influenced by recent big games (recency bias), player popularity, injury narratives, consensus rankings, and personal biases.

You are the reviewer assigned to audit the accuracy of fantasy football media's "expert" recommendations.

In this project, those narratives are treated as data. Article text has already been collected and sentiment is measured (ex. positive, neutral, negative tone), then compared with actual fantasy outcomes to test whether analyst tone provides genuine predictive signal or mainly reflects existing trends, recent performances, and broader media bias.

Your task is to decide whether sentiment adds predictive insight or simply reflects what was already obvious from known stats and public narratives. You should produce a short report that answers the following questions:

1. Are analyst narratives generally reliable for forecasting fantasy performance?
2. Is there any indication of predictive power in article sentiment?
3. What kinds of biases should be taken into account when reading fantasy outlooks?

Your conclusion should be an analysis of the expert sentiment. Make a claim about how helpful fantasy football media is when making decisions for your team.

All of this will be submitted electronically via a link to a github repository build for the case study AND selected documents will be submitted by hard copy as well.

Tips for success:

- Be bold. This is your chance to pick something you learned and share it.
- Don't overthink it. You are creating something for 2nd years, not Nobel prize winners.
- Don't overthink it. A clear presentation of fundamentals is more valuable than an unclear presentation of cutting edge techniques.
- Talk to the instructors. This is a creative assignment, and you are allowed to show ideas to people for comment.
- Talk to your fellow students. This is a creative assignment and you are allowed to show ideas to people for comment.

How will I know I have Succeeded? You will meet expectations on CS3 Create Case Study when you follow the criteria in the rubric below.

Formatting	• Topic – The topic of your CS3 assignment is one of your projects from this course. • Select one project from this course FROM YOUR GROUP. • It may be any of your three projects. • Once you have an idea for how to package it as a case study you may discuss it with the instructor (they usually help you develop it a bit and lock in) • Repository – A GitHub repo (and cloud storage folder if necessary) containing all materials • Submit a link to the repo • Everything is contained in the repo or linked to it if appropriate. • Contents • Hook document • Rubric • Various Materials (data, code, articles, etc.) • Elements from the MI3 rubric as appropriate • Use pdf format when possible • For code and data products use the appropriate format for whatever it is • Hard copy - The idea is that someone could pick it up and understand the case study. • Use a Manilla folder • One page hook document (pdf) paperclipped to left front • Rubric behind the hook document • Print out two sources and attach them to the right. • A blog post or similar explainer – more depth than the hook but still something that inspires/gives confidence

	• An article or similar – you have lots of freedom to select something that helps explain a component of the case study • Hook Document – 1 page pdf • Rubric – A rubric in this style and describing the deliverable you want the 2nd year to produce (about 2 pages in pdf format) • Materials – Files as appropriate
Hook Document	• <u>Goal</u>: This pdf should make a 2nd year UVA student excited to engage with your case study. • Create a scenario and place the student in the ‘driver’s seat’ • Make clear the topic/context/motivation • Indicate what deliverable the student is to produce but withhold details, those come in the rubric. This is a high level mission document not a specifications document. • One page maximum • PDF format
Rubric	• <u>Goal</u>: Explain the purpose, task, and criteria. This is where the details live to answer questions for the student. • Use this document’s format. There is no need to reinvent the wheel. • The goal is about 2 pages.
Materials	• <u>Goal</u>: Include materials necessary for a student to engage with the case study. • This will vary wildly from case study to case study. • Include a blog post or other type of explainer that helps motivate and start the project • Include more technical articles / documentation as appropriate • Data, code, etc. – so that they can perform the work • Place ALL materials in the repo as possible and in a cloud repository if too large for github.

Acknowledgements: Special thanks to Jess Taggart from UVA CTE for coaching on making this rubric. This structure is pulled from [Streifer & Palmer \(2020\)](#).

Fantasy Football Expert Narratives: Signal or Storytelling?

This reading gives you the context and technical tools to audit whether fantasy football expert analyses are actually useful for predicting player performance.

What is fantasy football?

Fantasy football is a management simulation game where participants manage fake NFL rosters. At its core, you act as the General Manager and Head Coach of a virtual roster composed of real-life NFL athletes. Your success depends on your ability to predict human performance using historical data, matchups, and injury reports.

The Draft

The season begins with the Draft where participants take turns selecting players from the entire pool of NFL athletes. Once a player is drafted in your league, they are off the board—no two teams in the same league can own the same player. This creates a market where you must balance the best player available with your specific roster needs.

Rosters

A standard fantasy roster mimics a real offensive unit, typically requiring you to start:

- 1 Quarterback (QB)
- 2 Running Backs (RB)
- 2-3 Wide Receivers (WR)
- 1 Tight End (TE)
- 1 Kicker (K)
- 1 Defense and Special Teams Unit (D/ST)

Scoring

Fantasy football converts real-world physical achievements into a singular mathematical score. While settings vary, the standard logic remains:

- Yardage: Players earn points for every 10 yards gained rushing/receiving or 25 yards passing.
- Touchdowns: The highest-value events (usually 4–6 points).
- Receptions: Many leagues use PPR (Points Per Reception), awarding a point simply for catching the ball, which adds a layer of value to high-volume receivers.
- Negatives: Fumbles, interceptions, and missed kicks subtract from your total.

Team Management

Once the season starts, your role shifts to a team manager. You must navigate:

- Weekly Matchups: You go head-to-head against one other manager in your league. The team with the most points at the end of Monday Night Football wins the week.
- The Waiver Wire: Not every impact player is drafted. The waiver wire is the "free agent" pool where you can "claim" players who are performing well or replacing injured starters.
- Trades: Managers can negotiate deals to swap players, often trading depth at one position (like RB) to upgrade a weakness at another (like WR).
- Start/Sit Decisions: Every week, you must decide which players move to your "Bench" and which stay in your "Starting Lineup." Points scored by players on your bench do not count toward your weekly total.

This is where the "expert" fantasy analyst industry was born. Because NFL performance is volatile, every decision is a gamble on the outcome of an event. You are trying to identify who has the highest ceiling and the safest floor in a specific window of time. This is why data analysis is so vital.

What articles am I reviewing?

Analyst outlook articles are weekly fantasy media pieces such as:

- Start/Sit recommendations
- Waiver-wire targets
- Matchup-based rankings
- "Boom or bust" profiles

These pieces are usually written in persuasive language ("must start," "high-upside," "avoid this week"). That tone can shape reader behavior, even when the evidence behind the recommendation is uncertain. You are auditing whether the tone of these recommendations helps forecast performance, or mainly reflects narrative framing.

What is sentiment analysis?

Sentiment analysis converts text tone into numeric values:

- Positive tone (optimistic language)
- Neutral tone
- Negative tone (pessimistic language)

In this project, sentiment scores are extracted from fantasy articles and linked to player-week outcomes. If sentiment is predictive, more positive writeups should generally align with stronger future fantasy outcomes. The core question is whether sentiment adds genuine signal beyond what is already known from stats and public context.

Fantasy media is influential, but influence does not equal accuracy. A positive article may coincide with a strong week for two very different reasons:

1. True predictive signal: analyst language captures real future value.

2. Narrative echo: analyst language just reflects obvious recent stats, bias, or hype.

If #2 dominates, sentiment can appear useful while adding little new information. Analysts often react to:

- Last week's breakout game (recency bias)
- Existing star reputation (popularity bias)
- Injury news and team narratives
- Consensus rankings already available elsewhere

In these cases, positive tone may track what already happened, not what will happen next. The goal is to determine whether analyst narratives are generally reliable, selectively useful, or mostly storytelling.

Technical Reading

***Important Note:** For this case study, sentiment scores have already been calculated from `text_dataset.json`. This study focuses mainly on extracting insights from these scores and examining the correlation with player statistics.*

This section should be a guided walkthrough of how the sentiment analysis was built and how the first exploratory checks were done. It provides context for how the project turns fantasy article text into a numeric feature and how that feature can be compared with player performance.

Sentiment analysis basics

Sentiment analysis is a way of turning text into numbers. A sentiment model maps words/phrases to positivity or negativity and combines them into a score. In this project, the key metric is a compound score from -1 to +1.

- Near +1: strongly positive tone
- Near 0: neutral/mixed tone
- Near -1: strongly negative tone

For the case study, that means we can treat analyst outlooks as data. If fantasy writers are truly helping forecast performance, then stronger positive sentiment might line up with better fantasy results. If not, the tone may be mostly storytelling, recency bias, or general enthusiasm.

Exploratory Data Analysis

A good first step is to inspect the sentiment distribution in the final dataset. First, read the csv and print the first few lines.

```
df = pd.read_csv("fantasy_dataset.csv")
print(df.head())
```

week	player_name	sentiment_compound	sentiment_pos	sentiment_neg	\
0	18	Mike Evans	0.6988	0.092	0.069
1	18	George Kittle	0.8740	0.108	0.053
2	18	Nico Collins	0.5429	0.056	0.022

Next, we want to get an overview of the sentiment scores in our dataset. To do this, define our target variable as a player + week record, and look at the distribution of sentiment scores.

```
player_week = (
    df.groupby(["week", "player_name", "position", "Team"])
        .agg(
            mean_sentiment=("sentiment_compound", "mean"),
            sentiment_std=("sentiment_compound", "std"),
            article_count=("sentiment_compound", "count"),
            mean_word_count=("word_count", "mean"),
            mean_pos=("sentiment_pos", "mean"),
            mean_neg=("sentiment_neg", "mean"),
            mean_neu=("sentiment_neu", "mean"),
            TotalPoints=("TotalPoints", "first"),
            Rank=("Rank", "first")
        )
        .reset_index()
)
print(player_week.describe())
```

	mean_sentiment	sentiment_std	article_count	\
count	2000.000000	2000.000000	2000.000000	
mean	0.396167	0.173630	1.909500	
std	0.533662	0.299197	1.627462	

This first check gives you a basic sense of the tone used in fantasy media. In this project, the average sentiment appears positive overall, which suggests that fantasy articles often lean optimistic. That is not surprising, since analysts are usually trying to recommend playable options rather than discourage readers. But it also raises an important question: if most of the writing is already positive, does that positivity actually help predict fantasy output?

The next step is to inspect the raw article text from `text_dataset.json`. This project does not only use the final numeric dataset; it also preserves the article-level text to help understand how sentiment is being generated. We want to examine the article metadata to get a broader view of our dataset. These checks matter because they help explain how the text data was organized before sentiment scoring.

For example, we can check out the unique player names from our sentiment analyses:

```
with open("Data/text_dataset.json", "r", encoding="utf-8") as f:
    data = json.load(f)

# Use a set to automatically handle uniqueness
unique_names = set()

for article in data:
    for player in article.get("players", []):
        name = player.get("name", "").strip()
        if name:
            unique_names.add(name)

# Sort alphabetically for easier reading
sorted_names = sorted(list(unique_names))

print(f"--- Player List Audit ---")
print(f"Total Unique Names Found: {len(sorted_names)}")
print("-" * 30)

for name in sorted_names:
    print(name)
```

We may also want to generate exploratory plots from our sentiment dataset. First, load the dataset.

```
# Load the data
df = pd.read_csv('../DATA/fantasy_dataset_final.csv')

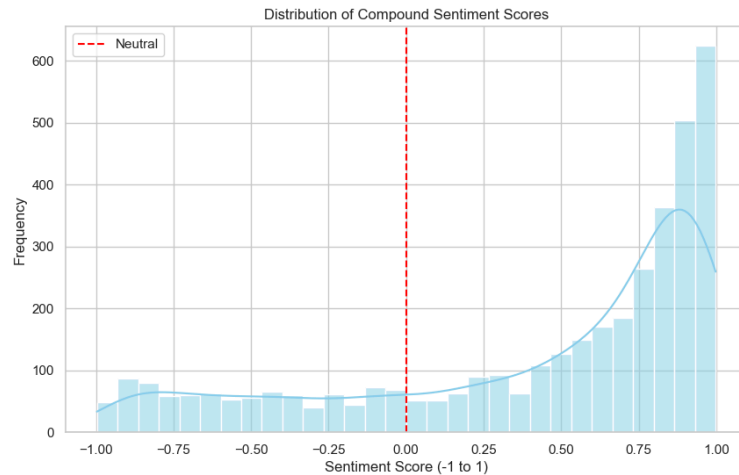
# Drop rows where we don't have fantasy points (for correlation plots)
df_clean = df.dropna(subset=['TotalPoints'])
```

Next, use seaborn and matplotlib to generate exploratory plots. For example, we can generate the distribution of sentiment scores.

```
# Plot 1: Distribution of Sentiment Scores
# Goal: See if analysts are generally positive, negative, or neutral.
plt.figure(figsize=(10, 6))
sns.histplot(df['sentiment_compound'], bins=30, kde=True, color='skyblue')
plt.title('Distribution of Compound Sentiment Scores')
plt.xlabel('Sentiment Score (-1 to 1)')
```



```
plt.ylabel('Frequency')
plt.axvline(0, color='red', linestyle='--', label='Neutral')
plt.legend()
plt.show()
```

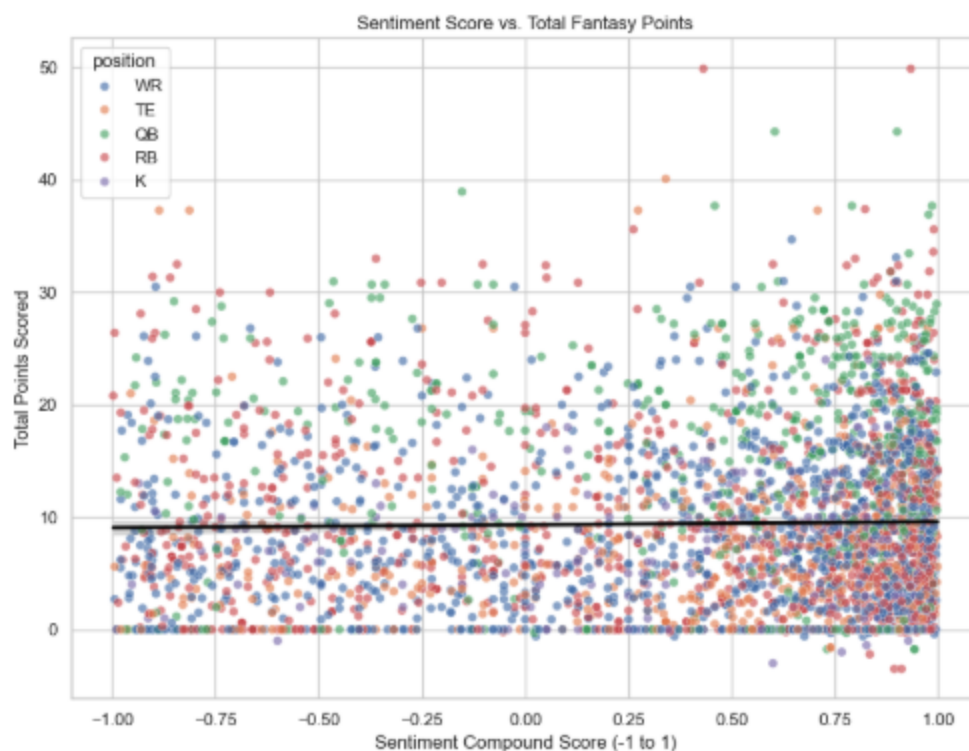


We can also generate a scatterplot comparing sentiment with total points. This is a helpful first look because it shows whether more positive language appears alongside better fantasy outcomes. It is important to note that these plots do not prove prediction. They only help the see whether there is an obvious pattern that may appear once we investigate further.

```
sns.scatterplot(data=df_clean, x='sentiment_compound', y='TotalPoints',
hue='position', alpha=0.6, ax=axes[1])
sns.regplot(data=df_clean, x='sentiment_compound', y='TotalPoints', scatter=False,
color='black', ax=axes[1])

axes[1].set_title('Sentiment Score vs. Total Fantasy Points')
axes[1].set_xlabel('Sentiment Compound Score (-1 to 1)')
axes[1].set_ylabel('Total Points Scored')

plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()
```



A deeper EDA is provided in the Technical References directory of this case study. This may be used as an initial reference point for generating the report on the effectiveness of article sentiment in predicting player performance.

There are some things that must be taken into consideration. For example, some positions may receive more positive framing, more caution, or more disagreement than others. Also, different positions may have different average or median total points. These exploratory plots do not answer the final question, but they help identify that sentiment AND performance may not be uniform across the NFL.

Analysis Approach

The question to answer is: are higher sentiment values associated with better future fantasy outcomes? Below are some initial ideas and things to consider when attempting to answer this question. You should use this example and build off of it, diving deeper into the player outlooks.

Testing Whether Sentiment Actually Matters

At this point, you have looked at the shape of the data, the distribution of sentiment, and a few basic relationships between tone and fantasy points. That is a good start, but it is not enough to answer the hook. To get closer to the real question you need to move into statistical testing and modeling.

The first thing I would do is establish a baseline. Before adding sentiment, ask how much fantasy performance can be explained by obvious football variables like position. That gives you something to compare against.

```
import pandas as pd
import statsmodels.formula.api as smf

df = pd.read_csv("../DATA/fantasy_dataset_final.csv")

# Baseline model: position only
baseline = smf.ols("TotalPoints ~ C(position)", data=df).fit()
print(baseline.summary())
```

This matters because if position already explains most of the variation, sentiment has to add something beyond that to be useful. A model that only repeats known role differences is not really helping the fantasy manager much.

Next, add sentiment to the model. This is the first real test of the hook question.

```
modell = smf.ols(
    "TotalPoints ~ sentiment_compound + C(position)",
    data=df
).fit()

print(modell.summary())
```

If sentiment_compound is not significant here, that suggests tone alone is not doing much after accounting for basic player role. If it is significant, that is still not the end of the story it could be picking up something else, like player popularity or matchup strength.

A better version of this analysis is to use the player-week dataset, since that reduces duplicate observations and gives a cleaner unit of analysis.

```
player_week = (
    df.groupby(["week", "player_name", "position", "Team"])
    .agg(
        mean_sentiment=("sentiment_compound", "mean"),
        sentiment_std=("sentiment_compound", "std"),
        article_count=("sentiment_compound", "count"),
        TotalPoints=("TotalPoints", "first"),
        Rank=("Rank", "first")
    )
)
```

```
.reset_index()
)

player_week["sentiment_std"] = player_week["sentiment_std"].fillna(0)
```

From there, you can test whether the average sentiment for a player-week predicts fantasy points.

Testing for Position-Specific Effects

One reason the overall relationship may look weak is that sentiment may behave differently by position. Analysts may be more optimistic about tight ends, more cautious about running backs, or more reactive to quarterback play.

You can test that with interaction terms.

```
interaction_model = smf.ols(
    "TotalPoints ~ mean_sentiment * C(position)",
    data=player_week
).fit()

print(interaction_model.summary())
```

This is useful because it asks a more realistic question: not “does sentiment always predict performance?” but “does sentiment matter more for some positions than others?”

If the interaction terms are meaningful, then the overall average may have hidden the real pattern. If they are not, then sentiment may be mostly narrative framing rather than a predictive feature.

Bias Checks

1. Recency bias

If analysts are mostly reacting to last week’s performance, sentiment may be echoing recent results rather than predicting future ones. A simple way to begin checking this is to compare sentiment with previous-week points if you have that data available, or with current-week performance to see whether tone is backward-looking.

2. Coverage bias

Some players get far more coverage than others. That can distort sentiment because star players are both discussed more and likely to receive more positive framing. If `article_count` matters, that suggests media attention itself may be part of the signal or part of the bias.

3. Analyst disagreement

If articles conflict with each other, that disagreement may be informative. A high standard deviation could mean a player is volatile or hard to project.

This is a strong next step because it goes beyond simple positivity and asks whether volatility in analyst opinion predicts volatility in player output.

Checking Model Quality

Once you fit a model, you should not stop at the coefficient table. You also want to check whether the model is actually behaving well.

```
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import seaborn as sns

plt.figure(figsize=(10, 6))
sns.scatterplot(x=predictions, y=residuals, alpha=0.5)
plt.axhline(0, color="red", linestyle="--")
plt.title("Residual Plot")
plt.xlabel("Predicted Fantasy Points")
plt.ylabel("Residuals")
plt.show()
```

This kind of plot helps identify whether the model is systematically missing certain kinds of players, such as boom/bust options or low-volume players. If the residuals fan out or cluster, that is a sign the relationship is more complicated than a simple linear model can capture.

Next Steps

The biggest questions remain open: do these outlooks truly contain predictive value, or are they mostly recycling recent performance, biases, and narrative framing? When sentiment is positive, is it revealing insight, or simply reflecting what the market already believes? And when analysts disagree is that a hidden signal about upside and volatility?

You should now have all the tools necessary to dive deeper into the data and decide whether fantasy football article tone is real signal, or just better storytelling. I encourage you to also find additional sources of fantasy writeups to get an even broader look at the media sentiment. This could open the door to doing a comparison between predictive accuracy of different fantasy media outlets. There are many more paths to explore with this baseline dataset.

Data Dictionary

This case study uses two datasets, which can be found in this repository:

<https://github.com/bowenslingluff/DS4002-CS3>

1. Data/fantasy_dataset_final.csv
2. Data/text_dataset.json

The goal is to evaluate whether fantasy analyst sentiment is genuinely predictive of player performance, or mainly reflects known information and media narratives.

1) fantasy_dataset_final.csv

Key fields

<u>Column</u>	<u>Column Name</u>	<u>Description</u>	<u>Example</u>
NFL Season Week	week	The week of the NFL regular season corresponding to the data point.	1, 2, ..., 18
Player Name	player_name	The full name of the NFL player associated with the fantasy football data record.	Drake Maye
Position	position	The player's primary on-field position (Offensive players only)	QB, WR, RB, TE, K
Team Abbreviated	Team	3 letter abbr. for the NFL team the player was rostered on at the time the data was recorded.	NE (New England Patriots)
Fantasy Points Scored	TotalPoints	The total number of fantasy points the player scored during that specific NFL week, based on standard fantasy scoring rules.	0 - 55.4
VADER Compound Sentiment Score	sentiment_compound	An overall sentiment score produced by the VADER sentiment analysis tool that summarizes the emotional tone of an article by combining positive, negative, and neutral sentiment into a single normalized value ranging from -1 (most negative) to +1 (most positive). Higher values indicate more positive sentiment.	.74 (strongly positive) -.84 (strongly negative)

Unit of observation

- A player mention tied to a given NFL week, with sentiment and performance fields merged into one row.

Primary use in this case study

- Compare sentiment to outcomes (e.g., 'TotalPoints', 'Rank')
- Check whether stronger tone aligns with better actual results
- Evaluate possible narrative/bias effects

Notes:

- sentiment_compound is measured on a scale from -1 to 1. 1 being the most positive, -1 being the most negative.
- If multiple analysts discuss the same player/week, you may see multiple rows for that player-week.

2) text_dataset.json

Unit of observation

- One fantasy article entry containing metadata and extracted player references.

Primary use in this case study

- Inspect how analysts frame players in language
- Identify possible narrative patterns (hype, recency bias, caution framing)
- Connect qualitative writing style to quantitative sentiment

Structure

- text_dataset.json is a list of article objects.

```
[
  {
    "meta_title": Article title,
    "meta_url": Article link,
    "meta_date": Article Publication Date,
    "intro_text": Article summary/introduction,
    ** players is a JSON Array of player analyses from the corresponding article.
    "players": [
      {
        "name": Player name,
        "raw_header": Raw article Header,
        "type": Article Type,
        "analysis": Paragraph analysis
      },
      ...
    ]
  }
]
```



FANTASY FOOTBALL RANKINGS: WEEK 15 MATCHUPS TO CONSIDER

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Kurt Mullen
@KurtKnowsBest

December 11, 2025

We've finally made it to the point in the season that all fantasy football managers work months to get to – THE PLAYOFFS! After an offseason of preparation followed by 14 weeks of struggle to get here, fantasy managers' entire seasons come down to the next three weeks to make it all worth it!

Making sure to get those lineups set to their absolute best is the key when it comes to “win or go home” situations like fantasy managers are facing this week. Like we have all season, let's walk through a handful of matchups at each position that could be worth considering before locking in those final lineups for Week 15.

It's always best to make use of all the tools available at Footclan HQ as we kick off the playoffs!

AD

Quarterbacks



draft rankings are no longer available for Jaxson Dart

After a hot start to his fantasy career, things have cooled off for [Jaxson Dart](#) in the Giants' offense. In his first seven starts, Dart was a streaming fantasy manager's dream, averaging 22.9 fantasy points per game and finishing as a top-7 QB four times. **What's added a safe floor to Dart's fantasy production has been the 42 yards he's averaged on the ground** when he is starting for the Giants. Dart already has seven rushing TDs, which have really aided his big fantasy performances. In his first game back from injury last week, though, Dart managed just 20 rushing yards on a career-low four rushing attempts against the Patriots. While that may have been a product of the matchup against a solid New England defense, if it doesn't go back to how it was before Dart missed two games to injury, it could really limit the ceiling he brings to fantasy lineups.

Luckily for Dart, he has a great matchup to help get him back on track in Week 15 against the Commanders. Washington's defense has been one of the best to target with fantasy QBs this season, allowing fantasy QBs to score 20+ fantasy points in a *very nice* 69% of their games this year. On the season, the Commanders' defense has allowed a top-12 QB in nine games already this season, including seven of their last eight games. Dart should have every opportunity to be a strong option to get fantasy rosters on their way to advancing to the semifinals.



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Trevor Lawrence
QB - JAX

vs NYJ

draft rankings are no longer available for Trevor Lawrence

[Trevor Lawrence](#) is quietly having himself a strong fantasy season for the Jaguars. Lawrence is currently the QB13 on the year and has really been a solid streaming option, finishing with 15+ fantasy points in eight of his last nine games, **including five top-12 finishes during that stretch**. In recent weeks, Lawrence has been able to find the end zone multiple times each game with 2+ TD passes in each of his last three games. Over those three games, Lawrence has a TD rate of 8%, the highest for any three-game stretch in his career thus far.

If Lawrence can keep his high TD rate rolling for fantasy managers, he will have a decently difficult matchup against the Jets to do so. **New York's defense has been one of the better units against the pass on the season as a whole**, giving up the 8th-fewest passing yards on the year, though they have allowed 20 passing TDs. Maybe more impressive is that the Jets haven't forced a single INT all year. Not a single one. For fantasy, over their last four games, New York has given up an average of 11.2 fantasy points to opposing QBs. Lawrence has a chance to break that streak for the Jets, but expectations for a week-winning type performance shouldn't be in store for fantasy managers.



Quinshon Judkins
RB - CLE

@ CHI

draft rankings are no longer available for Quinshon Judkins

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When a rookie comes out of the gates on fire like [Quinshon Judkins](#) did for the Browns, it can really change the landscape of a fantasy roster. Judkins hit the ground running in Cleveland, finishing as a top-12 RB in four of his first six games played, scoring five TDs in the process. Since then, though, things have slowed down for Judkins, getting in the end zone just twice since Week 8, and both of those TDs came in the same game. The change at QB in Cleveland hasn't helped Judkins much either. Prior to [Shedeur Sanders](#) taking over at QB, Judkins averaged nearly 69 rushing yards per game, but that number has declined to just under **55** yards a week over the last three games. The emergence of [Dylan Sampson](#) in the Browns' passing game hasn't helped things either, with the fellow rookie tallying nearly 60 receiving yards in two of his last three games.

The opportunity to get back on track should be there for Judkins in Week 15, though, [with a stretch of favorable RB matchups starting with a trip to take on the Bears](#). Chicago's defense has allowed the 6th-most rushing yards this season and has given up the 3rd-most carries over 20+ yards. For fantasy, the Bears have allowed a top-24 RB in five of their last seven games, and a total of seven RBs have hit that mark during that stretch. With cold weather likely to be a factor in this matchup, Judkins could be getting back on track for fantasy managers in such a crucial week.



Breece Hall
RB - NYJ

@ JAX

draft rankings are no longer available for Breece Hall

Despite all the worry this offseason that [Breece Hall](#) wasn't going to be a major part of the offensive gameplan in New York, the Jets RB has put together a really nice season, currently sitting as the RB14 on the year. Even with a combination of [Braelon Allen](#) and [Isaiah Davis](#) behind him to siphon carries away, **Hall has still seen around 18 opportunities per game for the Jets** this season on what has been one of the better running games in the league. What has really limited Hall's ceiling for fantasy managers has been the lack of TD opportunity, with just four total TDs (three rushing, one receiving) on the year. Hall has scored just once over the last month of games and has just one carry inside of the five during that stretch.

Things don't get much easier for Hall as we head into the fantasy playoffs with a matchup against the Jaguars on tap. Jacksonville's defense has allowed the fewest rushing yards in the league and just nine rushing TDs on the season. For fantasy, opposing RBs have been a bit of a mixed bag against the Jags. Despite being a tough run defense,



limited to a FLEX-level play in this matchup.



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Chris Rodriguez Jr.

RB - JAX

vs NYJ

draft rankings are no longer available for Chris Rodriguez Jr.

The RB situation in Washington has been a tough one to predict this season, but it feels like [Chris Rodriguez](#) has emerged as a late-season option that fantasy managers can somewhat rely on from this offense. While the Commanders' offense hasn't been quite the fantasy producer that it was last season, with plenty of missed time from QB [Jayden Daniels](#), Rodriguez has finished as a top-36 RB in five of his last seven games. What's really been valuable for Rodriguez's fantasy production has been the four rushing TDs that have come during that stretch, all of which came inside the red zone. With rookie [Jacory Croskey-Merritt](#)'s opportunities drying up, Rodriguez seems to be the best bet in this backfield to provide any fantasy production down the stretch of the season.

There should be plenty of opportunity for Rodriguez to produce again for fantasy managers this week with a nice matchup against the Giants on the road. **New York's defense has allowed the 2nd-most rushing yards in the league this season** and is allowing the highest yards per carry at 5.8 yards per rushing attempt. The last time we saw the Giants, they didn't allow a big RB performance for fantasy against the Patriots, but that ended a seven-game stretch where they had allowed a top-24 RB. Even with [Marcus Mariota](#) taking over at QB this week, Rodriguez should be a FLEX play with RB2 upside thanks to this favorable matchup.

Wide Receivers

Emeka Egbuka

WR - TB

vs ATL

draft rankings are no longer available for Emeka Egbuka

It has really been a ride for fantasy managers with [Emeka Egbuka](#) this season. The Bucs rookie came out of the gate on fire, catching five TDs in four of his first five career games and finishing as a top-10 WR three times during that stretch. **Since then, though, Egbuka has been a top-24 WR and has scored double-digit fantasy points just once**, way back in Week 10 when he was the WR4. There are plenty of reasons why fantasy managers have seen the dropoff in Egbuka's production down the stretch of the season, but that doesn't make the decision of keeping him in your



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The decision to get Egbuka back into your lineup will have to be made early this week with a matchup on Thursday night against the Falcons. Atlanta's defense has given up the 10th-fewest receiving yards on the season and is allowing under 200 passing yards per game. For fantasy, Atlanta has still been a team to target with fantasy WRs. Over their last seven games, the Falcons have allowed a top-24 WR each week, including five top-5 WR finishes during that stretch. **The tough call for fantasy managers with Egbuka is whether that production will come his way with all the returning WRs in Tampa.**

Ladd McConkey

WR - LAC

@ KC

draft rankings are no longer available for Ladd McConkey

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Despite high hopes that he could take a big step forward in the Chargers' passing attack this season, [Ladd McConkey](#)'s sophomore season has been a roller coaster for fantasy managers to ride. McConkey started the season finishing outside the top 24 for the first month, but followed that up with four-straight weeks inside the top 24. Since Week 9, though, it's been a "hot-and-cold" streak for McConkey, alternating useful fantasy weeks. What should be encouraging for fantasy managers needing production from McConkey is the consistent opportunity that the WR has seen, averaging about seven targets per game this season, though he's been a bit TD dependent, only finishing with 10+ fantasy points twice this year when he hasn't gotten into the end zone.

Things don't get easier for McConkey and the Chargers' passing game this week with a trip to Kansas City. The Chiefs' defense has been a strong unit against the pass this season, allowing the 9th-fewest passing yards this season and just 14 passing TDs on the year. Over the last month, Kansas City has allowed four top-24 WR finishes in just three games, and has given up five TDs in the air over that stretch. [With one of the lower expected point totals of the week](#), McConkey may once again be relying on getting into the end zone, and I'm not sure that's a bet that fantasy managers want to be making in such a crucial week.

Chris Olave

WR - NO

vs CAR

draft rankings are no longer available for Chris Olave



The [Chris Olave](#) experience for fantasy managers through his career has been a frustrating one. While it's clear that Olave is a talented WR, he's never really had the consistent QB play to produce for fantasy managers. It feels like Olave may have something with rookie QB [Tyler Shough](#) taking the reins in New Orleans. Since Shough took over at QB in Week 9, Olave has finished as a top-24 WR three times – one more than he had during the first eight weeks of the season. More importantly, Olave notched his first 100+ yard receiving game with Shough, his first since Week 8 of the 2024 season, so while he is seeing a similar number of targets that he was previously, the value of those targets seems to be going up with the QB change.

A division matchup against a tougher-than-expected Panthers defense could give Olave another chance to produce for fantasy managers this week. Carolina's defense has been decent against the pass this season, allowing just 16 passing TDs on the year, though they have managed the 2nd-fewest sacks in the league. Fantasy WRs have still been productive against the Panthers, though. Over their last five games, Carolina has allowed a top-24 WR each week, including Olave's second-best fantasy output of the season in their first matchup back in Week 10. While there may be some hesitation to try and rely on the Saints' passing attack, **Olave should provide a solid FLEX play for fantasy managers in Week 15.**

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Tight Ends

[Tyler Warren](#)

TE - IND

@ SEA

draft rankings are no longer available for Tyler Warren

The rookie breakout has been real for TE [Tyler Warren](#) this season in Indianapolis. Warren has been used all over the place in the Colts offense, playing only *half* of his snaps this season as an in-line TE and the rest moved around the formation with 30% of plays lined up in the slot. After a red-hot start to the year, Warren has cooled down a bit. The rookie finished as a top-12 TE in six of his first seven games this year, but has hit that mark just twice since Week 8 and has only scored one TD during that stretch. What's maybe more unsettling is the uncertainty at QB going forward for the Colts with [Daniel Jones](#) on season-ending IR and some combination of [Brett Rypien](#) and [Philip Rivers](#) potentially ending the season at QB in Indianapolis.

Regardless of who is under center this week for the Colts, Warren should still have an opportunity to produce for fantasy managers against a tough Seahawks defense. For most fantasy assets, Seattle has been a defense to avoid. The Seahawks have struggled against opposing TEs, though, allowing the third-most points per game to the position this season. Over their last five games, Seattle has allowed four top-12 TE finishes, and only one of those was

Fantasy Football Start/Sit Lineup Advice: Wide Receivers (Week 15)



by FantasyPros Staff | @FantasyPros | Dec 11, 2025

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Fantasy Football Start'em, Sit'em Lineup Advice

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Start'em

Emeka Egbuka (WR – TB)

Well, so much for the bounce back that I forecasted last week. Emeka Egbuka had nine targets that he turned into two receptions for 15 receiving yards. Since Week 7, he has had only two outings that landed him inside the top-36 for wide receiver weekly scoring (WR5, WR32). Since Week 7, he has had a 28.7% target share and a 36.4% first-read share that he has turned into only 48.1 receiving yards per game and 1.42 yards per route run. In those seven games, he has had eight red zone targets and six deep targets. Not all of Egbuka's struggles can be laid at his feet, as during this stretch, only 50% of his targets have been catchable. Much of this has been related to Baker Mayfield's struggles. Hopefully, with the Bucs at full strength in the wide receiver room this week, Egbuka can have a bounce-back game with Mayfield playing better. With the improved target competition, I do expect his market share in the offense to fall. Egbuka falls into the WR2/3 or flex territory this week. Since Week 10, Atlanta has allowed the second-most PPR points per target and the third-most receiving yards per game to perimeter wide receivers.

Chris Godwin (WR – TB)

Over the last two games, Godwin has had a 70.6% route share with a 20.7% target share, 66.5 receiving yards per game, 2.77 yards per route run, and a 22.2% first-read share. In those two games, he has had two red zone targets and one deep target. Godwin was the WR33 and WR27 in weekly scoring. Godwin is a strong WR3/flex. Since Week 10, Atlanta has allowed the 14th-most PPR points per target and the eighth-highest passer rating when targeted to slot receivers.

Darnell Mooney (WR – ATL)

Since Week 12, without Drake London, Darnell Mooney has only once finished higher than WR69 in weekly scoring. In those three games, Mooney has had a 14% target share with 35 receiving yards per game, 1.40 yards per route run, and a 19.6% first-read share. Since Week 12, he has had three red zone targets and two deep targets. It's been surprising how much he has struggled to command a high market share in the Atlanta passing offense with only Kyle Pitts to deal with weekly. He's a decent flex play this week with a good matchup. Since Week 10, Tampa Bay has allowed the 12th-most receiving yards per game and the 13th-most fantasy points per game to perimeter wide receivers.

Jayden Higgins (WR – HOU)

Since Week 10, Jayden Higgins has been the WR27 in fantasy points per game with an 18.1% target share, 46.8 receiving yards per game, 2.11 yards per route run, and a 21.6% first-read share. In those five games, he has had four red zone targets and six deep targets. This week, he faces an Arizona pass defense that has featured the fifth-highest rate of two high (57.1%). Since Week 10, against two high, Higgins has had an 18.4% target share with 2.14 yards per route run and a 22.1% first-read share. It's nice to see that his usage and efficiency have remained stable and in line with his overall numbers. Higgins is a strong WR3/flex again this week. Since Week 10, Arizona has allowed the most PPR points per target to perimeter wide receivers.

Jakobi Meyers (WR – JAC)

Since Week 11, Jakobi Meyers has been the Jaags' unquestioned WR1 with a 24.5% target share, 60.8 receiving yards per game, 2.29 yards per route run, and a 29.9% first-read share. In those four games, he has had six red

In his six games played this season, McLaurin has two top 24 weekly finishes (WR8, WR20) with seven red zone targets and seven deep targets. McLaurin has a 19.8% target share with 2.15 yards per route run and a 26.2% first-read share. If Marcus Mariota is looking to stretch the field, McLaurin (13.7 aDOT) should have a strong game this week. New York has allowed the seventh-highest deep ball completion rate, the third-most deep passing yards per game, and the eighth-highest passer rating to downfield passing. This feels like a nice bounce-back spot for McLaurin. Since Week 10, New York has allowed the 11th-most fantasy points per game and ranked 16th in receiving yards per game against perimeter wide receivers.

Deebo Samuel (WR – WAS)

Deebo Samuel is the WR22 in fantasy points per game with a 23.1% target share, 46.8 receiving yards per game, 1.69 yards per route run, and a 27.8% first-read share. He has 12 red zone targets and seven deep targets this season. Samuel could also have a strong day this week against a New York secondary that, since Week 10, has allowed the most PPR points per target and the ninth-most receiving yards per game to slot receivers.

Darius Slayton (WR – NYG)

Since Week 5, Darius Slayton has had a 13.9% target share with 45.3 receiving yards per game, 1.80 yards per route run, a 14.5-yard average depth of target, and a 17.5% first-read share, per Fantasy Points Data. In those six games, he has had one red-zone target, eight deep targets, and three top-36 finishes in weekly scoring (WR34, WR27, WR19). Slayton is a strong flex play this week against the Commanders. His downfield role should come in handy for Jaxon Dart. Washington has allowed the third-highest completion rate and the second-highest passer rating on deep passes. Since Week 10, Washington has also allowed the fifth-most PPR points per target to perimeter wide receivers.

Wan'Dale Robinson (WR – NYG)

Wan'Dale Robinson is having a wonderful breakout season as the WR20 in fantasy points per game with a 25.9% target share with 63.7 receiving yards per game, 1.90 yards per route run, and a 30.9% first-read share. Robinson should have another strong game this week. Since Week 11, Washington has led the NFL in two high rate (70%). Against two high, Robinson has maintained strong usage with a 25.6% target share, 1.81 yards per route run, and a 32.2% first-read share. Since Week 10, Washington has allowed the sixth-most PPR points per target and the 12th-most receiving yards per game to slot receivers.

Concerning Starts & Players to Fade

Christian Watson (WR – GB)

Christian Watson or Romeo Doubs will see the Patrick Surtain shadow treatment this week. Surtain has shadowed five times this season, following A.J. Brown, Calvin Ridley, Quentin Johnston, Terry McLaurin, and Ja'Marr Chase on 64.3–94.7% of their routes. Only McLaurin scored a touchdown with Surtain in tow, but none of those receivers surpassed 61 receiving yards with Surtain following them. Since Week 10, Christian Watson has been the WR13 in fantasy points per game with a 21.6% target share, 61.8 receiving yards per game, 2.49 yards per route run, and a 28.4% first-read share. In those five games, Watson has had two red zone targets and 11 deep targets. Since Week 8, Denver has utilized two high at the ninth-highest rate (57.1%). Since Week 10, against two high, Watson has ranked second on the team with a 17.2% target share with 2.26 yards per route run (leads the team) and a 25.7% first-read share. If Surtain doesn't follow Watson, I expect him to see a bump in usage, but I lean that he'll be the one that Surtain follows. I'm worried about his outlook this week with Surtain on him. Since Week 8, Denver has allowed the sixth-most receiving yards per game to perimeter wide receivers while also holding them to the 14th-fewest PPR points per target.

Courtland Sutton (WR – DEN)

Courtland Sutton is the WR23 in fantasy points per game with an 18.5% target share, 59.5 receiving yards per game, 1.89 yards per route run, and a 23.4% first-read share. Sutton is second on the team in red zone targets (ten) and deep targets (13). Sutton is headed for a down game this week. Since Week 12, Green Bay has utilized two high at the second-highest rate (69.5%). Against two high, Sutton's numbers have suffered with a 14% target share with 1.37 yards per route run and a 17.4% first-read share. Since Week 10, Green Bay has allowed the 13th-fewest fantasy points per game and the 14th-fewest receiving yards per game to perimeter wide receivers. Sutton needs a touchdown to save his fantasy day in Week 15.

Ladd McConkey (WR – LAC)

Last week, Ladd McConkey led the team with a 19.2% target share, which amounted to only five targets that he turned into one reception and 12 receiving yards. The entire Bolts' passing attack has to be downgraded with the passing volume in question. This week, he'll lead the way again versus Kansas City's two-high coverage. Since Week 11, Kansas City has had the third-highest two-high rate (62.2%). Since Week 6, against two high, McConkey has had a 24% target share with 1.19 yards per route run and a 24% first-read share (leads the team). McConkey's dip in efficiency versus two high is concerning, especially when you also consider that Kansas City has been good against slot receivers. Since Week 10, Kansas City has allowed the fourth-fewest PPR points per target and the eighth-fewest receiving yards per game to the position. If you have to play him this week, I get it, but don't expect a massive stat line.

Sit'em

Alec Pierce (WR – IND)

The Colts have been highly coverage-specific with their wide receiver usage, but they have a new quarterback and face a pass defense that has flipped back and forth between single and two high this year. I'm just going to look at the Colts' receiving options with a top-down perspective this week. Alec Pierce is the WR34 in fantasy points per game with six weeks as a top-36 wide receiver in weekly scoring. Pierce has an 18.7% target share with 69.9 receiving yards per game, 2.32 yards per route run, and a 22.8% first-read share. He has only five red zone targets as his main job has been as the deep threat, with 30.3% of his target volume coming via downfield targets (18.8 aDOT). This matchup doesn't set up well for Pierce this week. Since Week 10, Seattle has allowed the fewest PPR points per target and the second-fewest receiving yards per game to perimeter wide receivers. Also, they have allowed the eighth-fewest deep passing yards per game and the fifth-lowest passer rating to downfield targets.

Adonai Mitchell (WR – NYJ)

The entire Jets' passing attack is up in the air regarding their outlook for Week 15. The quarterback situation is unsettled, with Brady Cook possibly starting, but it's possible that Tyrod Taylor or Justin Fields could start. I'll update this situation on Friday or Saturday when we have a clearer picture of who will be under center this week. The outlook could change drastically depending on who draws the start in Week 15.

Jerry Jeudy (WR – CLE)

Jerry Jeudy had his second-best game of the season last week with 76 receiving yards (one touchdown) and a WR15 finish for the week. Since Week 12, he has had a 13.6% target share with a 29.6% air-yard share, 47 receiving yards per game, 1.70 yards per route run, and an 18.2% first-read share. In those three games, Jeudy has zero red zone targets and three deep targets. Jeudy is back to low-end flex territory this week. Since Week 10, Chicago has allowed the tenth-fewest receiving yards per game and the ninth-fewest PPR points per target to perimeter wide receivers.

Quentin Johnston (WR – LAC)

Sit Quentin Johnston this week. Two high coverage has been his kryptonite all season. Since Week 11, Kansas City has had the third-highest two-high rate (62.2%). Since Week 6, against two high, Johnston has had a 10.9% target share, 0.55 yards per route run, and a 13.8% first-read share. The Bolts will likely limit their passing volume again this week, and if Johnston is only a tertiary piece of a limited passing attack, he's likely to disappoint.

Xavier Worthy (WR – KC)

Since Rashee Rice's return, Worthy hasn't finished higher than WR28 in any week, and he has only two top 36 weekly finishes (WR28, WR33). Since Week 7, he has had a 15.3% target share, 44.4 receiving yards per game, 1.36 yards per route run, and a 19.4% first-read share. In those seven games, he has had three red zone targets and seven deep targets. Sit Worthy this week. Since Week 10, the Bolts have held perimeter wide receivers to the tenth-fewest PPR points per target and the 12th-fewest receiving yards per game.

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